

SEXUAL PROBLEMS

Ask about problems getting or maintaining an erection, pain with sex, painful ejaculation or loss of libido:

Problems getting or maintaining an erection

Does patient often wake with an erection in morning?

Yes

- If stress or anxiety ↗ 86.
- Ask about relationship problems, anxiety/fear about sex, unwanted pregnancy, infertility and performance anxiety.
- If sexual assault or abuse ↗ 88.
- In the past month, has patient: 1) felt down, depressed, hopeless or 2) felt little interest or pleasure in doing things? If yes to either ↗ 143.
- Discuss condom use. Ensure patient knows how to use condoms correctly.

No

- Assess CVD risk ↗ 127.
- Review medication: hydrochlorothiazide, spironolactone, risperidone, fluoxetine and amitriptyline can cause sexual problems. Discuss with doctor.
- In the past year, has patient: 1) drunk ≥ 4 drinks¹/session, 2) used illegal drugs or 3) misused prescription or over-the-counter medications? If yes to any ↗ 142.
- If patient smokes, encourage to stop ↗ 141.
- If low mood, stress or anxiety ↗ 86.
- If no better once chronic condition/s stable and treatment optimised, refer.

Painful ejaculation

- If genital symptoms ↗ 49.
- If urinary symptoms ↗ 59.
- Review medication: antidepressants and schizophrenia treatment can cause painful ejaculation. Discuss with doctor.
- If no cause found, refer.

Pain with sex (vaginal or anal). If painful ejaculation, manage in adjacent column.

Is the pain superficial or deep?

Superficial pain

- If genital symptoms ↗ 49.
- If anal symptoms ↗ 48.
- If urinary symptoms ↗ 59.
- Ask about vaginal dryness:
 - If woman > 40 years, ask about menopausal symptoms: hot flushes, night sweats, mood changes and difficulty sleeping. If yes ↗ 169.
 - Review medication: oral contraceptive, antidepressants and hypertension treatment can cause vaginal dryness. Discuss with doctor.
- Advise patient to use lubricant during sex. Ensure it is condom-compatible, avoid using petroleum jelly with condoms.

Deep pain

- If genital symptoms ↗ 49.
- If recurrent abdominal pain relieved by passing stool, with bloating, constipation and/or diarrhoea, **irritable bowel syndrome** likely. Refer to doctor.
- Refer if:
 - Heavy, painful or prolonged periods
 - Infertility
 - Abdominal/pelvic mass
 - Anal/rectal mass

- If low mood, stress or anxiety ↗ 86.
- If sexual assault or abuse ↗ 88.

Loss of libido

Ask if pain with sex or if problem with erections, and manage in adjacent columns.

- If stress or anxiety ↗ 86.
- Review medication: phenytoin, hydrochlorothiazide, spironolactone, chlorpromazine, risperidone, fluoxetine, amitriptyline and lopinavir/ritonavir can cause loss of libido. Discuss with doctor.
- In the past month, has patient: 1) felt down, depressed, hopeless or 2) felt little interest or pleasure in doing things? If yes to either ↗ 143.
- In the past year, has patient: 1) drunk ≥ 4 drinks¹/session, 2) used illegal drugs or 3) misused prescription or over-the-counter medications? If yes to any ↗ 142.
- Ask about relationship problems, anxiety/fear about sex, unwanted pregnancy, infertility and performance anxiety.
- If woman > 40 years, ask about menopausal symptoms: hot flushes, night sweats, mood changes and difficulty sleeping. If yes ↗ 169.
- If sexual assault or abuse ↗ 88.
- Assess the patient's contraceptive needs ↗ 154.
- Offer referral to counsellor.

If sexual problems do not improve, refer to specialist.

¹One drink is 1 tot of spirits, or 1 small glass (125mL) of wine or 1 can/bottle (330mL) of beer.